

Lack Of Reliability

A common misconception about pure-IP contact centers is their lack of reliability. However, in the last couple of years, service providers of packet switched data communications services have been successfully able to come out with robust and redundant infrastructure, providing highly reliable service. Wicom's contact center solution is worth mentioning here.

Poor Voice Quality

Another broad misconception has been of poor voice quality in a pure-IP environment. But that is not true, as many contact centers utilising pure-IP technology have reported excellent voice quality, which can be compared to TDM service. For enterprises, pure-IP comes in the form of a managed corporate network, not the public Internet, which still remains questionable for voice traffic.

Scalability Issues

In the past, due to the immaturity of voice over IP (VoIP), scalability was an issue for IP contact centers. Now with pure-IP technology, contact centers are able to quickly and efficiently scale up or down as needed on a site-by-site basis.

Technology Application Areas

Each industry vertical taps the potential of an enterprise communication technology differently. The following are a few examples:

Healthcare

The clinical departments can collaborate together without the constraints of conflicting schedules. Online meetings help them manage project communication and collaborations among the physicians, employees, vendors and contractors. Organisational communication and collaboration solutions offer the healthcare workers full mobility. By sharing medical resources available

Video conferencing solutions create an environment for face-to-face communication along with the capabilities offered by audio and Web conferencing software

in a central repository, skilled physicians provide their diagnostic assistance to remote areas. It is now possible to systematically track projects.

Healthcare departments manage scarce resources, making cost reduction for labour and for voice and data communications an essential aspect. IP telephony offers a proven path for cost reduction in communication.

Call Center

Person-to-person communication through IP enables enterprises of all sizes to increase revenues and reduce costs. Customer service agents who are physically distributed provide a centralised service offering better resource utilisation and business flexibility. It helps balance demand across time and locations. Location independence functionality helps match the needs of every person, function and service.

Education

Collaboration between distributed scientists and researchers throughout the world is possible. Today, students and professionals participate in online discussions and classrooms.

Banking And Finance

The unified mode to receive voice, video and data enhances productivity of sedentary and on-the-fly staff. It reduces maintenance costs by managing a single, integrated voice, video and data network in a central location, rather than maintaining separate voice and data networks in many locations. It enhances customer experience by decreasing their idle time, provides customised value-added services after customer identification, bridges a communication channel between the customer and the expert advisors, and makes services available in the most remote locations.

IP Conferencing helps easy connectivity to pioneers across the bank channels. It also improves employee satisfaction—provides ease of connectivity to people after detecting their availability, reduces time spent in unsuccessful attempts, employee education enables them to understand the service and thereby resolve issues effectively. IBM enhanced enterprise communication solution for the banking sector is a noteworthy technology here.

Others

Software companies, real estate, government, industrial and retail resort to communication technologies to empower on-the-fly and distributed decision makers and to make collaborative communications in real-time. Information Technology departments, media firms, brokerage houses, financial institutions use instant messaging tools to notify employees, customers and others, and implement group communications and messaging. ■

Technology Adoption Benefits

The following are the two most important benefits that can be extracted from the advanced software packages available in this domain.

Business Continuity And Desktop Productivity

Deployment of emergency notification and escalation services help locate any person, any group, anywhere, at any time, and at the same time deliver alerts and strategic intelligent information simultaneously across virtually every available communications device. It is possible to deliver high-speed acknowledged communications via landline, cell phone, e-mail, pagers, SMS, fax and satellite phone to individuals, employee desktops.

Emergency Operations

In case of unavailability, it is now possible for emergency departments to contact the emergency worker through phone, e-mail, and pager and organise an interactive mode of channel so as to ensure service by him. Emergency operation centers are able to provide better service since messages are tailored to the first responders with specific expertise. It effectively speeds up and enhances quality and reliability of communication.